

Figure 2: Centred camera view



Figure 3: The buttons window



Note: Be aware of the fact that 'numeric keys' refers to only those keys on the numeric keypad on a standard full-size keyboard, and not the ones above the alphabetical keys!

Table 1 lists some other common numeric keypad shortcut keys, and the actions they perform. The best way to get accustomed to the keyboard shortcuts is to experiment and use them as frequently as possible.

The mouse left-button is used to select and drag in Object Mode, while the right-click is used in Edit Mode (we'll cover the modes in more detail in the next part of the Let's Try). The mouse scroll wheel is used to zoom in and out.

The buttons window

Traditionally, the buttons window (see Figure 3) is placed in the lower portion of the screen. Its several buttons each have their own subset of functions:

1. The logic button: This is mainly used for game engines, and activated by using F4.
2. The script button: This connects various events to scripts, for complex projects and models.
3. The shading button: This consists of sub-functions to control light, opacity, colour, texture and other related settings. It is activated by using F5.
4. The object button: As the name suggests, it activates commands to work with objects, and is activated via F7.
5. The edit button: This is used to edit object components in Edit Mode; activated via F9.
6. The scene button: It is meant for rendering (still images) and animating (movies); activated via F10.

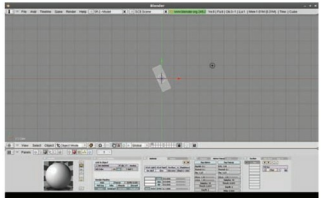


Figure 4: Shading panel



Figure 5: User Preferences window

Once you click a button, you will notice a set of numerous functions associated with it. For example, Figure 4 shows the *Shading* panel. We will cover each button and its functions in detail in subsequent parts of the Let's Try.

User Preferences window

This window is hidden by default, and contains some of the least-used features. To make it visible, click the header or menu bar at the topmost area of the program, and drag it downwards.

The window contains seven major heads, namely:

1. View and Controls
2. Edit Methods
3. Language and Font
4. Themes
5. Auto Save
6. System and OpenGL
7. File Paths

For beginners, and also to simplify the Let's Try, I recommend you retain the settings that come by default.

Well, that pretty much sums up the Blender interface. Don't worry if the description in this Let's Try, or the number of buttons in Blender, seems overwhelming. You'll get a grasp of it once you start using it regularly! In the next part in this series, we will go on to cover objects, materials, meshes, textures, lights and basic image rendering. **END** 

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